



This is a pretty silly thing to have to deal with in OS X—if you have minimised many documents of the same type, the only way to tell them apart is by hovering your mouse over them—more undesirable trackpad activity

even responds to the Windows key. There's a search text box in the start menu *à la* Vista, though searches aren't "live" (as you type). There aren't any cascading menus: your applications are presented to you, neatly categorised, in a window. There's even a search box to filter your selection; effectively, you have two-click access to all the items you need.

Ubuntu, too, takes the two-click approach. Applications are only a sub-menu away, though preferences and administration options are two steps away.

GNOME's Nautilus File Manager is very Explorer-like, just lacking eye-candy. GNOME also features taskbar buttons for every item on the screen. Overall, we prefer the taskbar-button approach that Windows and Linux have.

Pretty Pretty

OS X was the first to woo potential customers with shiny graphics, and "ooh"-inducing transitions; Microsoft followed suit with the Aero effects in Vista, and Novell started its own XGL project for 3D effects in Linux. Cool effects can make working slightly more pleasant, but does all this fanciness really help?

One of the supposedly utilitarian features of Vista's Aero is Flip 3D, which "uses the dimension of visual depth to give you a more comprehensive view of your open windows, helping you sidestep chaos even as you juggle myriad open files and programs." After starting Flip 3D, you scroll through open windows like a Rolodex. But remember that Flip 3D causes entry-level graphics cards (NVIDIA's 6600 and thereabouts) to stutter a bit.

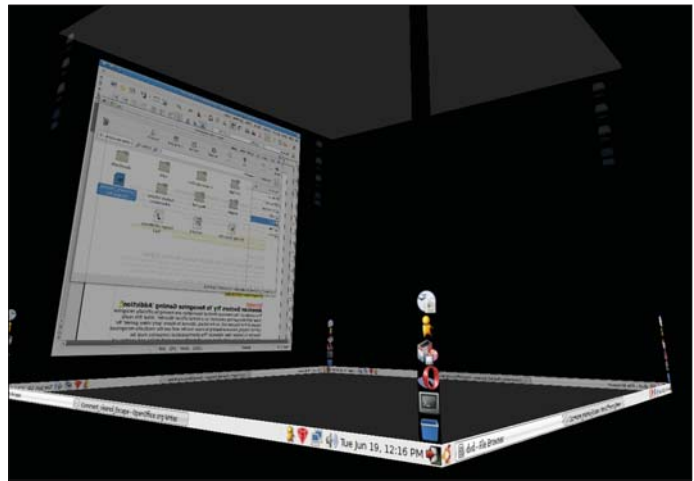
OS X has a good number of tricks up its sleeves; moving over the icons in the Dock enlarges them and the surrounding icons proportionately, making your desired icon easier to click on. Hit [F11], and all windows slide into the edges of your screen, revealing the Desktop. Hitting [F9] starts Exposé, which arranges all your windows on-screen—hover over them to find out what they are, and click on them to switch. On a MacBook or MacBook Pro, you'll have to hold down the [Fn] key and then hit [F9]—quite off-putting.

With SUSE and Ubuntu, you can either enable Desktop Effects from their respective administration menus, or install Beryl, a window manager built specifically to take advantage of all that XGL has to offer (the default used otherwise is Compiz). In all cases, workspaces are arranged on a 3D cube. If you hold down [Ctrl] + [Alt], click on the Desktop and drag, you can view the cube as if you were holding it in your hand—

imagine an actual rotating cube, with one window on the left, a document window on the top, and so on! Before XGL, you would switch between workspaces by moving your mouse cursor over the Workspace Switcher and using the scroll wheel—no keys to hold down, and considerably less mouse movement.

The verdict on the experience: in descending order, it's OS X, Vista, and Linux. The effects in OS X feel like a part of the OS, as opposed to the "slapped-on" feel of the other two. Apple developers know exactly what hardware the OS is going to run on (viz. the latest iMacs, MacBooks, etc.). Vista and Linux need to run on anything from a Pentium 4 to a Core 2 Duo system, so the option to turn off effects is a must.

Graphics aren't everything, though.



When you install Beryl on Ubuntu, you get to use the "transparent cube" to see all your applications. It's nice, but still not a great boost to usability

They Call Me The Seeker

Integrated search is a very handy thing to have on your PC—let's look at our contenders' offerings.

Vista's new Start Menu is commendable—no more infinitely cascading menus; menu items expand and collapse in the left pane of the Start Menu, and perhaps the most important addition is the Search box. Type in the first letters of the application or file you want, and Vista will search for it as you type, and display the results right there. It even supports searching for the first few letters of each word—"win me pl", for example, will bring up Windows Media Player. This has almost completely replaced Start > Run for us. The search box is also present in Windows Explorer, so instead of navigating through folders, you just enter the filename in the search box and Windows searches for the file in real-time. You can also search by document content, and add "tags" to files (like "vacation goa" for your Goa photos) to enable quicker searches. All very nicely done, though the indexing service does sometimes suck up resources.

The thing that started it all was OS X Tiger's Spotlight, which indexes all the files on your Mac. It's accessible through a simple shortcut ([Command] + [Space]); remember, we're on a laptop and don't want too much touchpad activity). You can also add "Spotlight Comments" to files—the precursor to Vista's tags—for quick searches.